



Q I should be happy that my baby's here, so why am I weepy and overwhelmed?

Your wonderful baby may be everything you dreamed of, and yet the challenges of new parenthood can be difficult to handle. The days following your baby's birth are intense, and emotions tend to seasaw as your hormones surge and you grapple with adjusting to your new role while feeling exhausted from the birth.

A touch of the blues

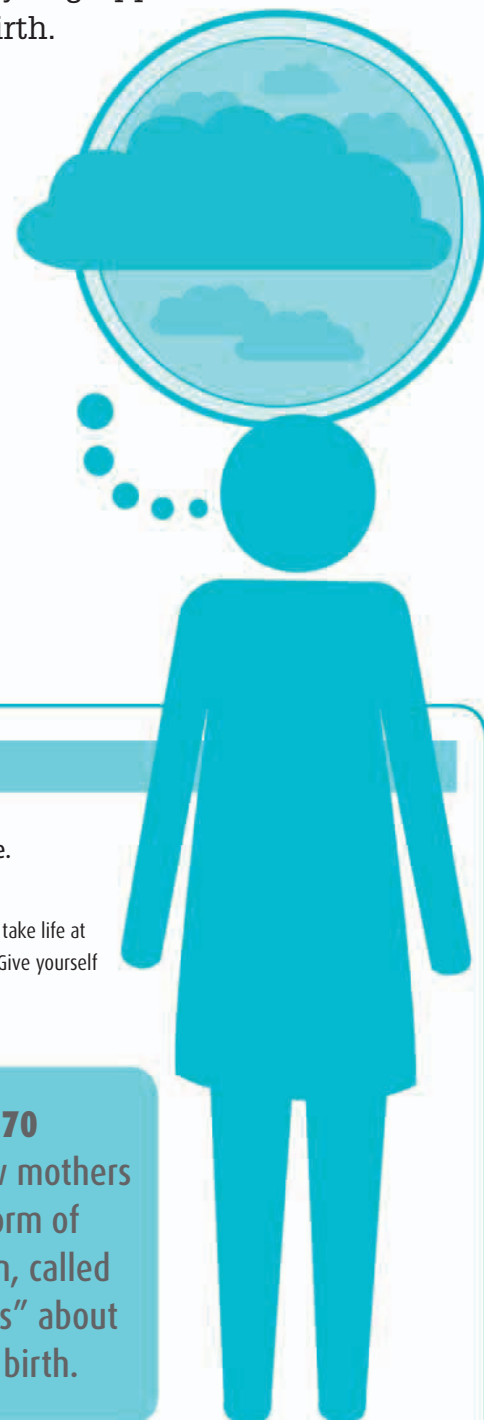
The "baby blues" are experienced by women shortly after giving birth (usually around day four). The blues tend to last a day or so. During this time women feel weepy, irrational, and generally a little overwhelmed by everything.

There are various reasons for the baby blues. After birth, your body undergoes dramatic changes as it returns to its pre-pregnant condition. The hormones progesterone and estrogen that helped sustain your pregnancy plummet and breast-feeding hormones rapidly rise. While these hormonal swings alone can play havoc, you are also recovering from

the after effects of the birth, including exhaustion, stitches, and perhaps major surgery. If you had a difficult birth experience, you may be struggling to process this. In addition, your breasts feel tender as they fill with milk, and your sleep is disrupted. Not least, you are adapting to your new role as a parent.

Feeling depressed

If, like 1 in 10 women, you still feel low and weepy beyond the baby blues, or find that negative feelings develop around one to two months after the birth, you may have postpartum depression (PPD) and should seek medical help.



SHORT-TERM BABY BLUES

There's no need to seek treatment for the baby blues since they will pass naturally as your hormones settle down, but getting adequate rest, feeling supported, and giving yourself time can make them more bearable. All these things will help with postpartum depression, too, although you will also need medical treatment.

» **Getting adequate rest:** we all struggle to cope when we are overly tired and when you have a new baby to take care of this can be exacerbated. After the exertion of the birth and delivery, you need quiet, restful time, which can be hard for new mothers to come by. Being inundated with visitors, coping with a noisy hospital ward, and dealing with a crying newborn and disrupted sleep are not conducive to good rest. Don't feel that you should "do it all"—putting your feet up while your baby sleeps isn't lazy, but crucial because it allows your body to recover from the birth and builds your energy back up.

» **Love and understanding:** partners and loved ones play a crucial role, both practically and emotionally. They need to encourage the mother to rest as much as possible while they hold the fort; be patient; allow the mother to cry and listen to her concerns; make sure she is well-nourished; and reassure her that her feelings are natural and that she will feel better soon. In turn, be honest with those around you about what you need.

» **Time to adjust:** having a baby may be the most life-changing event of your life, and yet it's a role that is hard to prepare for in advance. This is a period of adjustment. You

need to shift your priorities and take life at a slower pace for the moment. Give yourself time and be good to yourself.

Approximately 70 percent of new mothers experience a form of mild depression, called the "baby blues" about four days after birth.